

On Task Type Diversity

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Abstract

Seven coroutine libraries independently converged on a one-parameter task type. Each enforces domain-specific safety invariants through the promise. The only production two-parameter coroutine type - Asio's `awaitable<T, Executor>` - provides a type-erased default; users who opt out for performance immediately hit type incompatibility.

`std::execution::task` (P3552R3^[1]) adds a second template parameter with no default at all. This paper documents why the invariants differ by design and recommends that `std::execution::task` be scoped to the sender domain.

This paper is one of a suite of five. The companion papers are D4053R0^[12], “Sender I/O: A Constructed Comparison”; D4054R0^[13], “Two Error Models”; D4055R0^[14], “Consuming Senders from Coroutine-Native Code”; and D4056R0^[15], “Producing Senders from Coroutine-Native Code.”

Revision History

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- Initial version.

1. Disclosure

The authors developed and maintain Corosio^[3] and Capy^[4] and believe coroutine-native I/O is the correct foundation for networking in C++. The frame allocator gap (Section 3) was identified by Peter Dimov. The cross-library bridges (Section 5) were authored by Klemens Morgenstern. Neither is a co-author. The authors provide information, ask nothing, and serve at the pleasure of the chair.

The authors regard `std::execution` as an important contribution to C++ and support its standardization for the domains it serves well - GPU dispatch, heterogeneous execution, and compile-time work-graph composition among them. Nothing in this paper or its companions argues for removing, delaying, or diminishing `std::execution`. The authors' position is narrower: that networking and stream I/O present a compound-result structure that the three-channel model was not designed to carry, and that this domain is better served by a coroutine-native facility that can coexist with senders and interoperate where the domains meet. Two models, each correct for its domain, is a stronger standard than one model asked to serve both.

2. Coroutine Types in Production

folly::coro and Boost.Cobalt are in production at scale. cppcoro was deployed at Facebook before folly::coro replaced it. Asio's `awaitable` is included as the only production two-parameter coroutine type.

Library	Declaration	Params	Source
asyncpp	<code>template<class T> class task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
Boost.Cobalt	<code>template<class T> class task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
Capy	<code>template<class T = void> struct task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
cppcoro	<code>template<typename T> class task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
aiopp	<code>template<typename Result> class Task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
libcoro	<code>template<typename return_type> class task</code>	1	<code>task.hpp</code>
folly::coro	<code>template<typename T> class Task</code>	1	<code>Task.h</code>
Boost.Asio	<code>template<class T, class Executor = any_io_executor> class awaitable</code>	2	<code>awaitable.hpp</code>
P3552R3 (std)	<code>template<class T, class Environment> class task</code>	2	<code>task.hpp</code>

The interface converged. The machinery diverged. Cobalt embeds intrusive list nodes for cancellation. folly::coro integrates with Facebook's fiber scheduler. Asio's `awaitable` is coupled to `io_context`. Capy propagates `io_env` through `await_suspend(h, io_env const*)`, delivering executor, stop token, and frame allocator at the suspension point.

Asio's `awaitable` provides a type-erased default (`any_io_executor`). Users who replace it with `io_context::executor_type` for performance immediately hit type incompatibility: `await_transform` rejects the mismatch.^[26]

P3552R3^[1] adds a second template parameter: `Environment`. No default. The parameter exists because `task` is both a coroutine return type and a sender. Every function that returns `task` is coupled to the sender environment model.

As of P3552R3^[1], the wording declares `template<class T, class Environment> class task` with no default for `Environment` (`[execution.syn]`^[16], `[task.class]`^[16]). The design section states that "any empty type provides the default behaviour" but does not name or standardize such a type. The paper's own examples use `task<int>` with one parameter - ill-formed against its own wording. A future revision may add a default. Even so, the fragmentation argument in Section 2.4 holds: the `Environment` parameter exists so that users provide non-default environments, and the moment they do, the types diverge permanently.

Generic code that accepts `task<T>` does not accept `task<T, MyEnvironment>`. The moment any library in the dependency chain provides a non-default `Environment`, every function in the chain must agree on the type:

```

void spawn_work(std::execution::task<void> work);

std::execution::task<void, net_env> do_network();

spawn_work(do_network()); // does not compile:
                          // task<void, net_env> is not task<void>

```

Both are “the standard task.” They do not compile together. No shipped code outside the reference implementation uses a non-default `Environment`. The parameter solves a problem that seven independent libraries solved without it.

One-parameter task types compose by construction. Two-parameter task types fragment by default.

2.1 The Allocator Ceremony

[P3552R3](#)^[1] Section 4.6 shows how to enable allocator awareness. The user must define a custom environment struct and use it in every function signature:

```

struct alloc_env {
    using allocator_type =
        std::pmr::polymorphic_allocator<std::byte>;
};

std::execution::task<std::string, alloc_env>
read_body(tcp_socket& sock);

std::execution::task<json, alloc_env>
parse(std::string_view body);

std::execution::task<void, alloc_env>
write_response(tcp_socket& sock, std::string_view body);

```

Every production library:

```

task<std::string> read_body(tcp_socket& sock);
task<json>        parse(std::string_view body);
task<void>        write_response(tcp_socket& sock,
                                std::string_view body);

```

No standard allocator-aware environment type is provided. Two users who independently define semantically identical structs produce incompatible task types.

2.2 Two Empty Structs

Two libraries define empty environments. Identical behavior. Incompatible types:

```
// Library A
struct env_a {};
std::execution::task<int, env_a> compute();

// Library B
struct env_b {};
std::execution::task<int, env_b> fetch();

// Both environments are empty. Both produce identical
// default behavior. The types are incompatible.
```

The standard task type fragments on contact with itself.

2.3 Library Upgrade Breaks Downstream

A library that upgrades from the default environment to a custom one changes the return type and breaks every downstream caller:

```
// v1.0: default environment
std::execution::task<response> http_get(url_view);

// v2.0: needs allocator awareness
std::execution::task<response, http_env> http_get(url_view);

// Every downstream caller has a type mismatch.
```

Networking can use thread-local propagation for frame allocators. GPU can use device memory APIs. HFT can enforce zero allocation at compile time. Solutions exist when the promise serves its domain.

2.4 Adding a Default Does Not Prevent Fragmentation

A default delays fragmentation; it does not prevent it. The `Environment` parameter exists so that users provide non-default environments. The moment they do, fragmentation begins - and it is viral: every function in the call chain must agree on the type.

Asio demonstrates the mild case. Asio's second parameter is an executor - a narrow concept with a fixed interface (`execute(f)`). Type erasure works: `any_io_executor` wraps any executor behind virtual dispatch. The default covers most users. Even so, users who replace `any_io_executor` with `io_context::executor_type` for performance immediately hit type incompatibility: `await_transform` rejects the mismatch^[26], cross-context `co_await` fails at the

type level^[27], and custom awaitables cannot compose with Asio's `awaitable` without matching the executor type^[28]. The friction is documented across multiple StackOverflow questions. This is the mild case because the escape hatch exists - users can always fall back to `any_io_executor` at the cost of one virtual dispatch per operation.

P3552R3^[1]'s `Environment` is the severe case. The environment is not a narrow concept with a fixed interface. It is an open query-response protocol: `get_stop_token`, `get_scheduler`, `get_allocator`, and any user-defined query, each with a different return type. The set of queries is unbounded. A type-erased `any_environment` would require `std::any`-style dynamic dispatch for every query, each with a different return type. This is technically possible. It destroys the compile-time composition that is the sender model's entire value proposition - completion signatures become runtime-dependent, `then` and `let_value` cannot deduce return types, and the zero-overhead property that justifies the model's complexity is gone. An `any_environment` that preserves the sender model's compile-time properties does not exist and cannot exist, because the query set is open-ended. The fragmentation is not a performance trade-off with an escape hatch. It is a choice between fragmentation and abandoning the properties that make the sender model worth having.

The diversity in the table above is not fragmentation. It is fitness.

3. Why the Invariants Differ

Every production library extends the C++20 awaitable protocol with domain-specific safety invariants. P3552R3^[1]'s `await_transform` + `affine_on` maintains executor continuity and stop token propagation for recognized senders within `std::execution` (P2300R10^[9]). Four gaps remain. Sections 3.1, 3.2, and 3.4 are engineering gaps with papers in progress - they may be closed in future revisions. Section 3.3 is architectural: the sender model's deferred delivery and the networking model's immediate delivery are contradictory requirements that no single task type can satisfy.

3.1 Frame Allocator

`affine_on` returns the coroutine to the correct scheduler thread. The thread-local frame allocator on that thread is whatever the previous coroutine left - not the allocator for this chain. No hook exists between `affine_on` completing and the coroutine body resuming where TLS can be restored. Peter Dimov identified this gap. P3980R0^[6] addresses allocator sourcing but does not restore TLS on resumption.

3.2 Foreign Awaitables

P3552R3^[1]'s `await_transform` recognizes senders. A non-sender awaitable - `cppcoro::task<int>`, a Cobalt awaitable, any C++20 awaitable - passes through without `affine_on`, without stop token wiring, without environment propagation. All three invariants are lost. Networking libraries reject non-conforming awaitables at compile time. P3552R3^[1] permits them. Non-sender domains require their own task types.

3.3 Timing

Senders deliver context through `connect` / `start` after the coroutine frame is allocated. Networking delivers context at `co_await` time through `await_suspend`. The frame allocator must be available before the child's `operator new` (`[dcl.fct.def.coroutine]`^[16]) - before any sender machinery runs. No mechanism in `std::execution` (P2300R10^[9]) delivers an allocator to `operator new` without `allocator_arg_t`. Deferred delivery serves senders. Immediate delivery serves networking. The requirements are incompatible.

3.4 Symmetric Transfer

The sender-awaitable's `await_suspend` returns `void`, foreclosing symmetric transfer. Jonathan Müller confirmed in P3801R0^[7]: *“a thorough fix is non-trivial and requires support for guaranteed tail calls.”* Dietmar Kühl documented the gap in P3796R1^[8].

4. The `IoAwaitable` Protocol

`IoAwaitable` is not proposed for standardization. It is the authors' design and is presented here as one example of what domain-specific compile-time enforcement looks like - not as the only possible design. The cross-domain bridges in Section 5, authored independently by Klemens Morgenstern, provide the stronger evidence that domain-specific protocols are the norm. P4003R0^[2] defines the concept:

```
template<typename A>
concept IoAwaitable =
    requires(A a, std::coroutine_handle<> h,
             io_env const* env)
    {
        a.await_suspend(h, env);
    };
```

The `io_env` pointer carries three fields:

```
struct io_env
{
    executor_ref executor;
    std::stop_token stop_token;
    std::pmr::memory_resource* frame_allocator;
};
```

These are the three invariants Section 3 identifies as gaps in P3552R3^[1]. `IoAwaitable` delivers all three at `await_suspend` time. Every awaitable in the chain receives the environment. No deferred delivery. No timing gap.

4.1 Closed by Design

The promise's `await_transform` passes `io_env*` to `await_suspend(h, env)`. Any awaitable that does not accept the second parameter fails to compile. The check applies to all awaitables - coroutine-backed or not. A foreign awaitable with the standard `await_suspend(coroutine_handle<>)` signature does not compile. The invariant violation is a type error, not a silent runtime degradation.

4.2 Contrast with `task`

P3552R3^[1]'s `await_transform` calls `as_awaitable(expr, promise)`. For recognized senders, this wraps them in an awaiter that applies `affine_on` and stop token propagation. For non-sender awaitables, the expression passes through unchanged - no `affine_on`, no stop token, no environment propagation. The `Environment` template parameter controls what the promise advertises through `get_env()`, but the awaitable never sees it unless it is a sender that goes through `connect / start`.

Property	<code>IoAwaitable</code>	P3552R3 <code>task</code>
Foreign awaitable <code>co_await</code> ed	Compile error	Compiles, invariants lost
Non-coroutine awaitable gets environment	Yes (<code>io_env*</code> in <code>await_suspend</code>)	No (only senders via <code>connect</code>)
Enforcement point	<code>co_await</code> site (compile time)	<code>connect / start</code> (runtime path)
Invariant violation mode	Type error	Silent

`IoAwaitable` demonstrates that the `await_suspend` signature is the natural enforcement point, and it works for all awaitables, not just coroutine-backed ones. P3552R3^[1]'s permissive model is appropriate for the sender domain. It cannot serve as a general-purpose correctness boundary because it has no mechanism to reject non-conforming awaitables.

5. Cross-Domain Bridges

The `cross_await`^[17] repository (Klemens Morgenstern) contains four cross-library composition examples. All four require explicit adaptor code.

Outer library	Inner library	Adaptor file	Lines
Cobalt	Capy	<code>cobalt_capy.cpp</code>	67
TMC	Capy	<code>tmc_capy.cpp</code>	51
Capy	Cobalt	<code>corosio_cobalt.cpp</code>	105
Capy	TMC	<code>corosio_tmc.cpp</code>	60

From `cobalt_capy.cpp` :

```
template<typename T>
struct capy_task_adaptor {
    capy::task<T> tt;
    capy::io_env env;
    std::stop_source src;
    boost::asio::cancellation_slot slt;

    template<typename Promise>
    auto await_suspend(std::coroutine_handle<Promise> h) {
        auto& p = h.promise();
        env.executor      = p.get_executor();
        env.stop_token    = src.get_token();
        env.frame_allocator = p.get_allocator().resource();
        slt = p.get_cancellation_slot();
        slt.assign([this](auto ct) {
            if ((ct & boost::asio::cancellation_type::terminal) !=
                boost::asio::cancellation_type::none)
                src.request_stop();
        });
        return tt.await_suspend(h, &env);
    }
};
```

The bridge knows both protocols. It is specific to the pair. There is no generic bridge because the invariants are domain-specific.

5.1 Sender Bridges

D4055R0^[14]: consuming senders from `IoAwaitable` code. One class template. Satisfies `IoAwaitable` , propagates stop token, dispatches back to the originating executor. `set_error(std::error_code)` becomes `io_result<T>` - no exceptions. Does not use `std::execution::task` .

D4056R0^[15]: producing senders from `IoAwaitable` code. Compound I/O results are rejected at compile time. The coroutine body inspects the compound result, reduces it to `error_code` , and the bridge routes it through three channels without exceptions.

5.2 The Bridge Pattern

All six bridges share three properties:

- **Opt-in.** No bridge is automatic.
- **Explicit.** The bridge code is visible. No silent invariant translation.
- **Responsibility.** The bridge author maintains invariants across the boundary.

Cross-domain composition works. The C++20 awaitable protocol is the surface all bridges bottom out to.

6. No One True Task

Gor Nishanov stated the design intent in [P1362R0](#)^[10] (Section 3.7):

“The separation is based on the observation that coroutine types and awaitables could be developed independently of each other by different library vendors. In a product, one could use N coroutine types that describe how coroutine behaves and M awaitables describing how a particular asynchronous API should be consumed. Users can freely mix and match coroutines and awaitables as needed.”

And at CppNow 2017^[11]: “We did not want to tie it to a particular task library. [...] We wanted them to be open.”

`promise_type` is the extension point. Unifying all task types into one forces either carrying every domain's invariants (bloat) or carrying none (unsafe). [D4053R0](#)^[12] and [D4054R0](#)^[13] document a concrete example: I/O returns `(error_code, size_t)`, and the three-channel model forces a routing decision that loses the byte count, the channel semantics, or both.

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